

Congress for World Peace in New York in 1949, and paraded before the world's press as a puppet of the Soviet state. Only after Stalin's death in 1953 did he achieve rehabilitation of his status with the Tenth Symphony, one of his most popular works.

Shostakovich's wife, Nina, died in 1954, and although it is rumored that he had affairs with at least two of his students in the 1940s and 1950s, when he remarried it was to a Leninist activist, Margarita Kainova, in 1956. The marriage ended in divorce just three years later, and he married his third wife, 27-year-old Irina Supinskaya, in 1962.

By the mid-1960s, Shostakovich was becoming increasingly ill. He was diagnosed as suffering from polio, although it seems more likely that his condition was motor neuron disease. In the final decade of his life, he gradually lost the use of most of his limbs and had a number of falls resulting in broken bones. His sight was also severely restricted, and he suffered a number of heart attacks, not helped by his lifelong heavy smoking and drinking. Nevertheless, he continued composing for as long as he was able to wield a pencil. He died of lung cancer in 1975.